

lieve your portfolio is being actively managed. However, a true financial planner (and not a broker, who is transaction-oriented) should be focused more on the game plan and less on making money by moving it around. It's a "slow and steady wins the race" approach. Too many transactions may also mean that they are making commissions on each move—a sign that they are not truly working for you.

8. The plan given to you seems too good to be true.

If it seems too good to be true, it probably is. If that tax strategy seems a little lofty, or you are introduced to a strategy that you've never heard of that flies in the face of everything you know to be true and legal, then you may eventually find yourself in hot water. Although the advisor may be liable, you are ultimately the one who will have to clean up the mess if your financial actions were unruly.

9. They tell you they can time the market.

I don't care who your financial planner is—they can't time the market. If they call you wanting to make drastic changes based on what they *think* the market is going to do, run. What they

should really be focused on is *you, your goals, and a plan* (and portfolio) that will weather the good times and the bad. Sure, small adjustments here and there may be prudent, but moving everything in and out of different asset classes is a losing game. They may get it right a few times, but all it takes is one bad calculation to lose everything you have gained.

IF IT'S TIME TO FIRE YOUR FINANCIAL PLANNER

Please do them a favor and give them a call. Sometimes things are lost in translation, or a breakdown in communication is accidental. In my experience, people can be short-sighted, focusing on returns and setting unrealistic expectations based on short-term performance. When the markets are booming, people expect consistent double-digit returns and forget not-so-distant times when that wasn't the case. And vice versa: After a stretch of poor performance, the same person may be convinced that the bad times will never end and want to stash all their money under the bed, forgetting to take the bad times with the good to achieve an overall rate of return that will help them attain their goals.

By calling your financial planner and giving them a chance to explain